

Data Visualisation & Storytelling

Excel Online | Turning numbers into decisions

Day 1 • 11:45 – 13:00 (narrative framework revisited Day 2, 09:00)

WHERE THIS MODULE SITS IN THE DATA LIFECYCLE



FOUR KEY PRINCIPLES FROM THIS MODULE

- Choose before you build — decide what question the chart answers before opening Excel.
- Remove before you add — the default Excel chart needs things taken away, not added.
- The title is the message — an insight-led title does the interpretive work for the reader.
- Consistency builds credibility — colour, label style, and axis treatment should be uniform across a report.

CHART TYPE CHOOSER

Chart type	Use when...	Avoid when...
Bar (column)	Comparing values across distinct categories (teams, directorates, months)	You have more than ~12 categories — a table may be clearer
Line	Showing how a metric changes over time — trends, trajectories	Your x-axis is categorical, not time-based (use bar instead)
Pie / Donut	Showing how a whole divides into parts, with ≤ 4 clear segments	You have more than 4-5 segments, or differences between slices are small
Scatter	Exploring whether two numeric variables are related	Your audience is non-technical and unfamiliar with scatter plots

CHART DECLUTTER CHECKLIST

Chart border	Remove it — adds visual weight with no information value.
Gridlines	Soften or remove — light horizontal gridlines only if they aid reading precise values.
Legend	Remove if the chart has only one data series. Move inside the chart if space allows.
Data labels	Use labels OR an axis, not both. Labels on bars can replace the y-axis entirely.
Colour	Use one colour for all bars. Use a second highlight colour only for the bar that carries the key message.
Axis titles	Remove if the axis label is self-explanatory. Every element that isn't earning its space should go.

WRITING INSIGHT-LED CHART TITLES

■ Descriptive (weak)	✓ Insight-led (strong)
Mandatory Training Completion by Directorate	Three directorates below 80% completion as of October
Staff Absence by Month	Absence peaked in January — 2.1% above the quarterly average
Spend by Cost Centre	Two cost centres exceeded budget in Q3 — together accounting for 68% of the overspend

CONTEXT → INSIGHT → RECOMMENDATION FRAMEWORK

CONTEXT	INSIGHT	RECOMMENDATION
What is the situation? What data are we looking at, and why does it matter?	What does the data show? What is the finding — the one thing the audience needs to know?	What should happen next? What action or decision does this finding call for?

A chart without a narrative is just a picture.

The Context → Insight → Recommendation framework is practised in full on Day 2. Start applying it now: every chart you build should have a title that reflects the Insight, and you should be able to say in one sentence what the Recommendation is.

